Maison Margiela
PARIS

BIANCHETTO

Research for

MaisonMargiela/folders

ARCHIVES DEPARTMENT

ARCHIVE RESEARCH

Document purpose:

For MaisonMargiela/folders exhibition, we research four codes selected by our team that have shaped our identity: Artisanal, Anonymity, Tabi and Bianchetto. Brought to life through exhibitions and experiences across four cities in China, each code explores a distinct facet of the Maison’s vocabulary.

This document focuses on **Bianchetto**, our white overpaint technique introduced in 1989, researching into its origins and development, tracing how the act of covering in white transforms garments, objects and interiors into a code of the house.

Paint as a medium

Paint has held **a central role** for us in Maison Margiela's creative and visual vocabulary since the beginning. In the very first collection, the soles of the Tabi were dipped in red paint, leaving **footprints** on the white cotton canvas covering the runway.

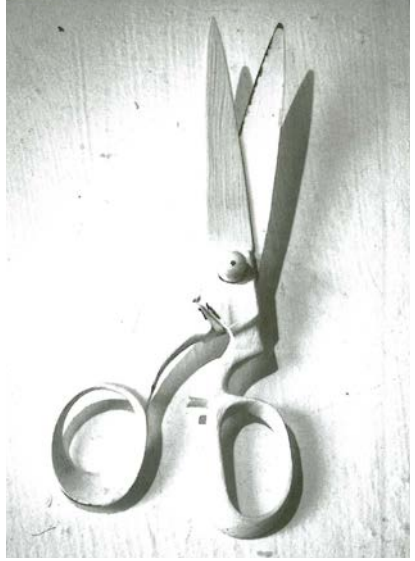
This gesture introduced paint as **a means of leaving a trace**, evoking notions of **movement** and **temporality**. From the outset, paint functioned as **a medium** that revealed rather than concealed **the passage of time**.

Over time, paint became **a recurring element**, applied to garments, shoes, furniture, and even to the models' skin.

Bianchetto is our white overpaint technique that leaves visible brush strokes and transforms surface into a blank canvas. Bianchetto was introduced in 1989 by the house through an overpainted collection of Salvation Army furniture for its design studio, in the same year extending the treatment to the Tabi shoe. Items were painted white to enact **a tabula rasa** (a blank slate). Through this act, the past of each object was partially erased, allowing it to be recontextualised and imbued with **new meaning**.

The white overpaint is an extension of white as a house code. It is applied to garments, objects and interiors, the paint will naturally crack and fade over time, gradually revealing visible signs of use- a signature of Maison Margiela.

This is symbolic of **the beauty of impermanence**, **transformation** and **decay**.



Garde-robe pour femme
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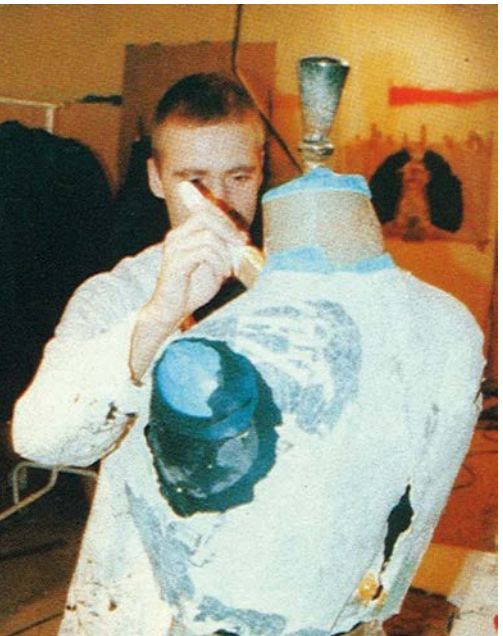

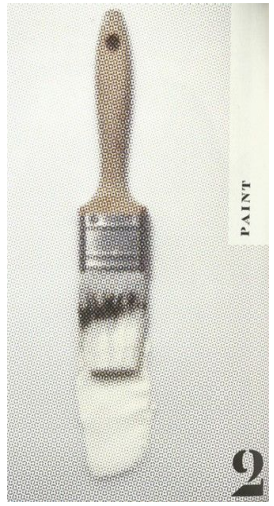
PAINT
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Maison Margiela
PARIS
7.4—7.18

Initial Research from the Archive

Spring Summer 1991
White painted denim top

Spring Summer 1991
Denim dress with jeans cut into skirt, painted white

Autumn Winter 1991
White painted cut denim trousers belt

Spring Summer 1992
White painted denim pants with black hand-painted stripes

Spring Summer 1992
White painted five pockets denim pants

Spring Summer 1993
White painted denim skirt

Men Spring Summer 1999
White painted jacket (line 0)

Women Autumn Winter 2000
White painted leather jacket

Men Autumn Winter 2001
'Artisanal' painted denim pants

Men Autumn Winter 2001
White painted ‘artisanal’ denim jacket

Men Autumn Winter 2001
White painted waistcoat

Women Spring Summer 2001
White painted raincoat

Women Spring Summer 2002
White painted denim jacket

Men Autumn Winter 2004
Borsalino hat painted white

Pitti Uomo 2006
White painted ankle boots

Pitti Uomo 2006
White painted leather pants laced on the sides

Women Spring Summer 2007
White painted spike form denim trainers

Women Spring Summer 2009 - Look 3
White painted rolled-up shoulders tailored jacket

Men Spring Summer 2010
White painted Replica sneakers without laces

Men Spring Summer 2012
White painted canvas brogues

Men Spring Summer 2012
White pained loafers

Women Autumn Winter 2012
White painted cement covered heels

Artisanal Spring Summer 2013
A ‘cigarette line’ tailored jacket is cut on a stockman in ecru cotton canvas. It is treated with rabbit-skin glue, then painted black and white. Worn with white painted clog boots.

Artisanal Spring Summer 2013
Silk thread embroidery, echoing brushstrokes on a painting and a floral motif embroidery dating from the 1920’s are alternately mounted onto a silk panel.Worn with white painted clog boots

Artisanal Spring Summer 2015 - Toile look 9
White painted toile of hand-sewn silk ribbons dress with an exaggerated train.

Artisanal Spring Summer 2015 - Toile look 11
White painted toile of an embroidered chiffon coat worn with cuffed denim shorts. A fully embroidered sequin and chiffon bra and tap knickers ensemble completes the look.

Artisanal Spring Summer 2015 - Toile look 24
White painted toile of a long coat painted with silk-faille Ottoman lining that becomes a dress with a centrally embroidered antique 'Globe de mariage'.

Women Autumn Winter 2016 - Look 7
Green and white painted embroidered sweater

Artisanal Spring Summer 2017 - Look 11
White painted frontier hat

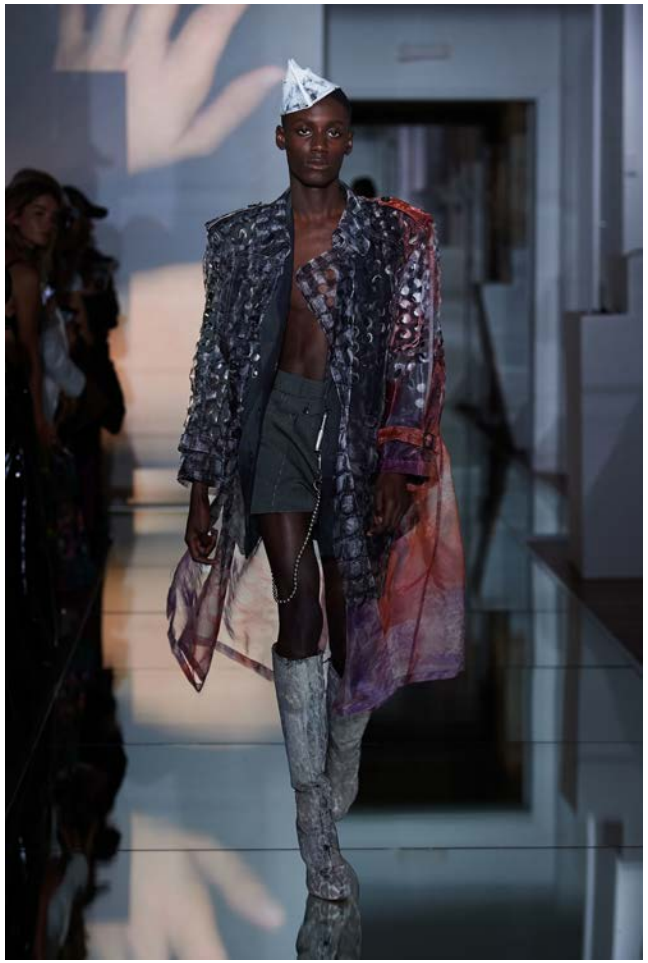
Artisanal Autumn Winter 2017 - Look 23
Pin-tucked painted wool knit jumper with sequin embroidery and piercing detail

Mutiny Campaign 2019
White painted décortiqué wool coat

Mutiny Campaign 2019
White painted tailored jacket

Artisanal Co-Ed Autumn Winter 2019 - Look 5
White painted beret and white painted leather belt

Artisanal Co-Ed Autumn Winter 2019
White painted hat



Artisanal Co-Ed Autumn Winter 2019 - Look 30
White painted leopard printed boots

Artisanal Co-Ed Autumn Winter 2019 - Look 10
White painted leather gloves

Artisanal Co-Ed Spring Summer 2020
White painted leather gloves

Co-Ed Spring Summer 2020 - Look 16
Khaki green hat painted white / White painted leather boots

Co-Ed Spring Summer 2020 - Look 1
Black felt beret painted white with black spot merry widow veil

Co-Ed Autumn Winter 2020 - Look 13
White painted hat

Artisanal Co-Ed Autumn Winter 2020
White painted pointy shoes

Artisanal Co-Ed Autumn Winter 2020
White painted pointy shoes

Co-Ed Spring Summer 2021
White painted single strap Nina shoes

MM X Reebok 2021
White painted décortiqué Reebok sneakers

Co-Ed Spring Summer 2022
Toile padded jacket with a white-painted embroidered lining

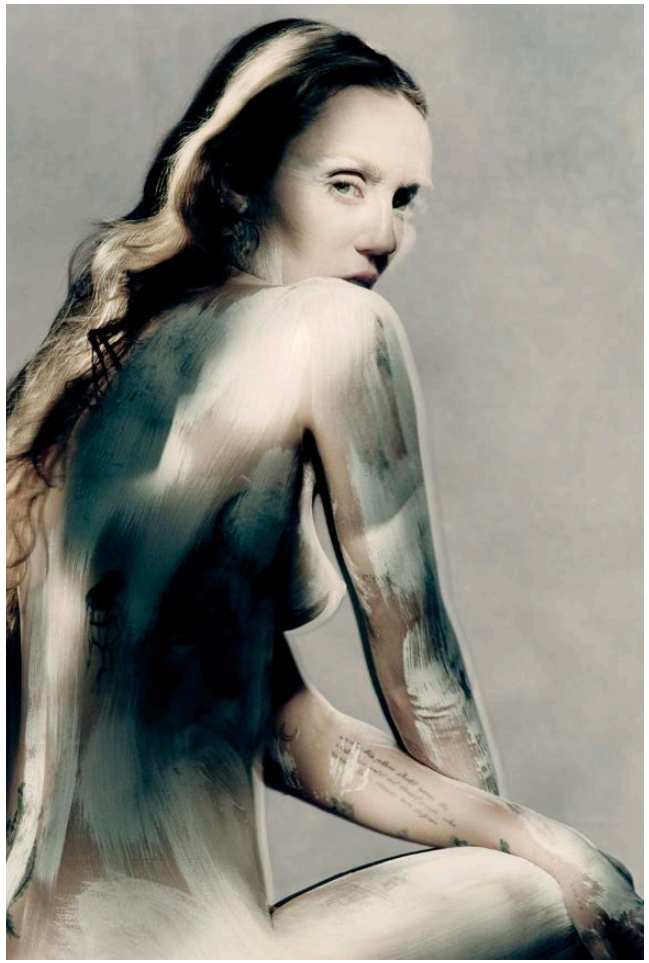
AVP Autumn Winter 2025
The 5AC Loved to Death medium crafted in leather with a crackled paint treatment. A matte coating is applied by hand over soft calf leather, designed to flake with time and reveal wear and imperfection.

AVP Spring Summer 2025
Inspired by Greek slippers and crafted from soft calfskin, with the Maison's Bianchetto technique, designed to evolve with wear.

Icons - Autumn Winter 2022
Crafted in vintage nappa leather, these block-heel ankle boots feature the Maison's Bianchetto treatment, which wears with use for an evolving look.

Artisanal Autumn Winter 2025 - Look 5
A hand-painted jersey top and brocade skirt worn under a plastic coat flocked with a faded burgundy brocade motif.

Artisanal Autumn Winter 2025 - Look 5
The white denim trousers are hand-painted, worn with cognac leather (heelless) Santiago boots hand-painted in a trompe l'oeil (evoking the brush strokes of Gustave Moreau).



Autumn Winter 2025
The Maison's Bianchetto technique transforms Miley Cyrus in portraits by Paolo Roversi, for the Autumn-Winter 2025 Collection.